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# Spell Out Grief: A Journey Through Loss and Love

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**Citation :** Donnette Martelle (2025) Spell Out Grief: A Journey Through Loss and Love. Peercite J Ment Health. 3(S1):726-729.

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### Abstract :

Grief represents a universal yet profoundly individual experience, shaped by personal history, cultural expectations, and intergenerational dynamics. This qualitative narrative explores the lived experience of a mother, grandmother, and great-grandmother navigating cumulative losses—including multiple marital dissolutions and the suicide of a son. Using autoethnographic reflection, this paper examines the emotional, physical, and psychological manifestations of grief and the adaptive processes that contribute to meaning-making and healing across generations. The study highlights grief as a cyclical, non-linear process and underscores the importance of integrating self-compassion & family connection into bereavement adaptation.

**Keywords:** grief, bereavement, autoethnography, intergenerational healing, suicide loss, maternal grief

## Introduction:

Grief is an inevitable human experience with profound emotional, psychological, and physiological implications (Stroebe & Schut, 2010). While traditional grief theories, such as Kübler-Ross's five stages (1969), offer a framework for understanding, contemporary scholarship emphasizes grief's cyclical and individualized nature (Neimeyer, 2012). This study presents an autoethnographic account of grief across multiple losses—four marriages (three ending in divorce and one in death) and the suicide of a son—through the perspective of a mother, grandmother, and great-grandmother. The aim is to explore how grief is experienced, expressed, and integrated across time and familial generations.

## Aim:

**The primary aim of this study is to explore:**

1. The emotional, physical, and psychological dimensions of grief experienced by a mother, grandmother, and great-grandmother.
2. The intergenerational effects of grief and its influence on familial relationships.
3. The coping mechanisms, meaning-making strategies, and healing trajectories following cumulative losses.

## Methods and Materials:

Design:

This research adopts a qualitative autoethnographic approach, allowing for reflective interpretation of lived experiences within their emotional & sociocultural contexts (Ellis, 2004). Autoethnography enables the intersection of personal narrative and social understanding, transforming private pain into shared knowledge.

Data Source:

Primary data were derived from the author’s personal journals, reflective writings, & narrative recollections spanning 2019–2024. Secondary material included letters, family correspondences, and photographic archives.

Analytical Framework:

Thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006) was employed to identify recurring patterns within emotional, physical, and cognitive expressions of grief. Coding focused on four core domains:

- Emotional expression (e.g., guilt, helplessness, yearning)
- Physical response (e.g., fatigue, appetite changes)
- Cognitive (e.g., self-blame, identity reconstruction)
- Relational dynamics (e.g., support for grand children)

Results:

Emotional Dimensions:

Grief manifested as profound sadness, guilt, and maternal inadequacy following the suicide of the author’s son, Jeremy Kesner Christopher (1973–2019). Emotional oscillation between despair and resilience reflected the cyclical nature of mourning. “The baby I carried for nine months was gone. I wanted to die and join him.” This emotional intensity was tempered by a continued maternal bond with her surviving son, reframing grief as both loss and enduring love.

Physical Manifestations:

Common physiological responses included insomnia, chronic fatigue, and somatic pain. These align with empirical findings linking grief with altered neuroendocrine and immune responses (Buckley et al., 2012).

| Table 1. Physical Symptoms Associated with Grief | Reported Intensity |
|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| Sleep disturbance                                | Severe             |
| Appetite fluctuation                             | Moderate           |
| Fatigue and low energy                           | Severe             |
| Somatic aches (chest tightness, headaches)       | Moderate           |

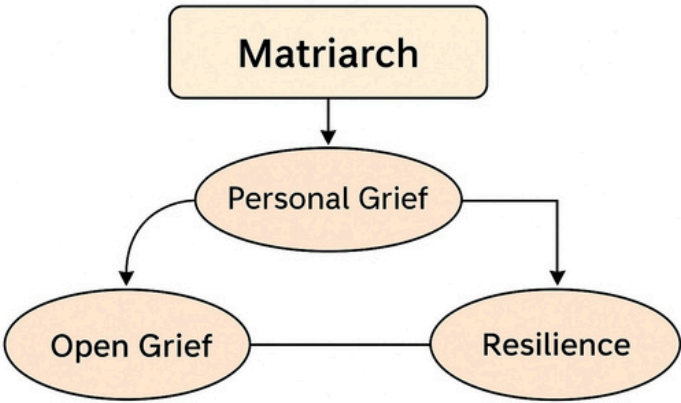
Psychological Impact:

Periods of depression, anxiety & dissociation were reported, consistent with models of complicated grief (Prigerson et al., 2009). Feelings of maternal failure & existential questioning dominated early bereavement stages, later evolving into acceptance and meaning reconstruction.

Intergenerational Grief and Family Dynamics:

As a matriarch, the author faced the dual burden of personal mourning & supporting younger generations. Her approach evolved from silence to open communication, modeling vulnerability and resilience.

Figure 1: Intergenerational Model of Grief Adaptation



Discussion:

The findings underscore grief as an ongoing, adaptive process rather than a finite stage-based phenomenon. The narrative reveals how personal losses—divorce, widowhood, and suicide—interact to shape cumulative grief & resilience trajectories.

The Role of Meaning-Making:

The search for meaning was central to healing, supporting Neimeyer’s (2012) argument that reconstructing personal narratives facilitates adaptation. Expressions of continued bonds, such as speaking to the deceased son in prayer, reflect resilience-building mechanisms (Klass, Silverman & Nickman, 1996).

Intergenerational Healing:

Grief, when shared openly, fosters intergenerational empathy and cohesion. The transformation from guilt to compassion and from silence to dialogue exemplifies post-traumatic growth within family systems (Tedeschi & Calhoun, 2004).

**Integration of Love and Loss:**

Rather than "moving on," integration of loss into life's fabric reflects a healthy bereavement outcome. Maintaining symbolic connection with the deceased sustains meaning and emotional continuity.

**Conclusion:**

This autoethnographic exploration reveals that grief, particularly maternal grief following suicide, is neither linear nor resolvable but integrative. Healing arises from acceptance, remembrance, and the capacity to hold love & pain simultaneously. The findings affirm the importance of open communication, intergenerational support, and self-compassion as essential to transforming grief into enduring love.

**Conflict of interest:**

Author declares there is no conflict of interest.

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